

Returns to Representation: Girls' Youth Sports Participation Following the Founding of the WNBA

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Abstract

This paper investigates the impact of a women's professional sports league on girls' youth sports participation. Using the Women's National Basketball Association's (WNBA) inaugural season in 1997 as treatment, I apply two-way fixed effects methods to determine if there are any effects of the league's formation on the participation of girls in high school sports. Across four sports, I find modest increases in basketball and track participation, while cross-country and soccer do not exhibit any statistically significant effects.

1 Introduction

In 1997, the Women’s National Basketball Association (WNBA) held its inaugural season. Since its conception, the league has expanded from an initial six teams, to a recently announced 18 teams by 2030. This growth across states presents an interesting question: does the existence of a professional sports league encourage girls to engage in youth sports?

2 Literature

3 Methodology

3.1 Data

3.2 Estimation

The proliferation of the WNBA lends itself to a differences-in-differences design. However, using the canonical differences-in-differences design would lead to biased estimates due to staggered treatment. Thus, I shift to the design of [Callaway*SA], which accounts for the bias by construction.

The estimating equation is as follows:

$$Y_{it} = \alpha_i + \lambda_t + \delta \cdot D_{it} + \varepsilon_{it} \tag{1}$$

where Y_{it} is state i ’s participation in a sport at time t , α_i accounts for state-level fixed effects, λ_t accounts for year effects, D_{it} is a treatment indicator, indicating if state i has a WNBA team in year t . Thus, δ represents the average treatment effect for a unit treated in a given expansion cohort.

4 Results

5 Robustness

6 Discussion

7 Conclusion